

A

Extreme adjectives

There are many 'extreme' adjectives we use to say that something is very good, or very small, or very surprising, etc.

We were lucky – the weather was **marvellous** [very good; *syns* **terrific**, **wonderful**, **amazing**].

Don't go and see that film – it's **awful** [very bad; *syn* **dreadful**].

I was **delighted** she passed her exam. [very pleased]

It's a nice modern flat, but it's absolutely **tiny** [very small].



I wasn't very hungry, but they gave us a **huge** meal. [very big; *syn* **enormous**]

You should watch that programme; you'll find it absolutely **fascinating** [very interesting].

Everyone was really **exhausted** by the end of the day. [very tired]

Bungee jumping is the most **terrifying** thing I've ever done. [very frightening]

Computers are an **essential** part of modern life. [very important and necessary]

The food was **delicious** [very good; but usually only for food].

Language help

The food was **absolutely marvellous**. (NOT The food was ~~very~~ marvellous.) We can use **absolutely** or **really** before extreme adjectives, e.g. *absolutely awful*, *really terrific*, but we can't use **very**.

We use **very** or **really** with gradable adjectives which do not have an extreme meaning, e.g. *very big*, *very good*, *very nice*, *very tired*, *really good*, *really tired*, etc. (NOT ~~absolutely~~ big)

B

Adjectives ending in -ing and -ed

A large group of adjectives can have an **-ing** or **-ed** ending. The **-ing** ending describes a person, thing or situation; the **-ed** ending describes the effect on someone of this person, thing or situation.

I don't know if other people were **bored**, but I thought it was a very **boring** lesson.

The weather is so **depressing** at the moment; it's making everyone feel **depressed**.

Common mistakes

I was bored by that film. (NOT I was ~~boring~~ by that film.)

We're very interested in the new designs. (NOT We're very ~~interesting~~ in the new designs.)

These adjectives can all end in **-ing** or **-ed**, depending on the meaning.

It was really **tiring** going up that hill. [making you feel tired]

I was **amazed** she could climb that wall. [very surprised]

My exam results were very **disappointing** [not as good as I expected].

She was **annoyed** that I forgot to tell her. [angry]

I kept calling her Emma, so I was **embarrassed** when Ben told me her name was Angela.

[feeling a bit stupid because of something you have said or done]

The map he gave us was very **confusing** [difficult to understand].

We were **shocked** by the violence in the film. [very surprised in an unpleasant way]